



GOLDEN HORIZONS PRESENTS

Your Retirement Abroad Starter Guide

5 Destinations Where Your Dollar
Goes 2-3x Further

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Your Daily Retirement-Abroad Morning Brief

YOUR NEXT CHAPTER STARTS HERE

Why Consider Retiring Abroad?

What if your retirement savings could go 2-3 times further? What if a two-bedroom apartment with a view cost less than your current mortgage? What if a full dinner out ran under five dollars?

For thousands of Americans, this is not a hypothetical. It is Tuesday.

Retiring abroad is no longer a fringe idea. The combination of rising domestic costs, excellent international healthcare, and easier global connectivity has made it a serious financial strategy. Social Security checks arrive by direct deposit anywhere in the world. Medicare may not follow you overseas, but in many countries the cost of private health insurance is a fraction of what you pay at home.

This guide introduces five destinations where your dollar stretches furthest, your quality of life improves, and the transition is smoother than you might expect. Each was chosen for its combination of affordability, infrastructure, safety, and expat-friendliness.

1.5 million+ Americans living abroad in retirement	40-70% average cost-of-living savings vs. the US	50+ countries with viable retiree visa programs
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Let us walk you through each one.



Lisbon, Portugal

Europe's sunniest capital with old-world charm

Estimated monthly cost: 1,800 - 2,400 (couple)

Lisbon offers cobblestone streets, world-class seafood, and a healthcare system ranked 12th globally. The D7 passive income visa is designed for retirees: prove a steady income of roughly 800/month per person and you can live legally in the EU. English is widely spoken, especially among younger Portuguese, and the expat community is well-established.

Rent (1-bed, city center): 700 - 1,100/mo

Dinner for two: 25 - 40

Private health insurance: 80 - 150/mo

Public transit pass: 40/mo

Visa: D7 Passive Income Visa (straightforward)

Best for: Culture lovers, foodies, EU access



San Jose Region, Costa Rica

Tropical nature meets affordable healthcare

Estimated monthly cost: 1,500 - 2,200 (couple)

Costa Rica has been a retiree favorite for decades, and for good reason. The Pensionado visa requires just 1,000/month in pension income. The public healthcare system (CAJA) is available to all legal residents for about 80-100/month and covers everything from doctor visits to surgery. The climate in the Central Valley stays spring-like year round, and flights to Miami take under three hours.

Rent (2-bed, Central Valley): 600 - 900/mo

Dinner for two: 15 - 30

CAJA healthcare: 80 - 100/mo (full coverage)

Groceries: 250 - 350/mo

Visa: Pensionado (1,000/mo pension income)

Best for: Nature lovers, easy US access, healthcare

DESTINATION 3 OF 5



Pokhara, Nepal

Himalayan lake town where 800/mo buys a dream

Estimated monthly cost: 600 - 1,000 (couple)

Pokhara is where your dollar goes furthest on this list. A two-bedroom apartment with a lake view rents for around 250/month. A full dinner out costs under three dollars. The town sits at the foot of the Annapurna range and attracts a growing community of long-stay foreigners. Nepal offers tourist visas extendable up to 150 days, and many retirees do visa runs to India every few months. Internet is reliable, the pace is gentle, and the mountains never get old.

Rent (2-bed, lake view): 200 - 350/mo

Dinner for two: 3 - 6

Private hospital visit: 5 - 15

Monthly budget (all-in): 600 - 1,000

Visa: Tourist visa, extendable (150 days/year)

Best for: Adventure seekers, ultra-low cost, mountain lovers

DESTINATION 4 OF 5



Penang, Malaysia

Southeast Asian food capital with first-world healthcare

Estimated monthly cost: 1,200 - 1,800 (couple)

Penang consistently ranks as one of the best places to retire in Asia. The food alone is worth the move, a plate of char kway teow costs about a dollar. Georgetown is a UNESCO World Heritage site with vibrant street art, colonial architecture, and a deeply multicultural community. English is widely spoken. Healthcare at private hospitals like Penang Adventist is world-class and costs a fraction of US prices. A specialist visit runs about 15-25 dollars.

Rent (2-bed, Georgetown): 400 - 700/mo

Street food meal: 1 - 3

Private health insurance: 100 - 200/mo

Specialist doctor visit: 15 - 25

Visa: MM2H or DE Rantau (digital nomad)

Best for: Foodies, healthcare quality, English speakers



Lake Chapala, Mexico

The largest American expat community south of the border

Estimated monthly cost: 1,200 - 1,800 (couple)

Lake Chapala, just 45 minutes from Guadalajara's international airport, is home to the largest concentration of American and Canadian retirees in Mexico. The climate averages 75 degrees year-round. The expat infrastructure is mature: English-speaking doctors, familiar grocery brands, active social clubs, and a cost of living that stretches Social Security further than anywhere in the continental US. The Residente Temporal visa is straightforward with proof of income.

Rent (2-bed, Ajijic): 500 - 900/mo

Dinner for two: 12 - 25

Private health insurance: 100 - 250/mo (age-dependent)

Domestic help (weekly): 30 - 50/mo

Visa: Residente Temporal (proof of income)

Best for: Easiest transition, large expat community, proximity to US

AT A GLANCE

Side-by-Side Comparison

Destination	Monthly Cost (couple)	Healthcare	Visa Difficulty	English Spoken
Lisbon, Portugal	1,800 - 2,400	Excellent	Moderate	Good
Costa Rica	1,500 - 2,200	Very Good	Easy	Moderate
Pokhara, Nepal	600 - 1,000	Basic	Easy	Moderate
Penang, Malaysia	1,200 - 1,800	Excellent	Moderate	Very Good
Lake Chapala, Mexico	1,200 - 1,800	Good	Easy	Very Good

All costs are approximate and based on a comfortable but not lavish lifestyle. Your actual costs will depend on your choices, location within the country, and exchange rates.

WHICH ONE IS RIGHT FOR YOU?

- **Want the lowest possible cost?** Pokhara, Nepal. Nothing else comes close.
- **Want world-class healthcare?** Penang, Malaysia or Lisbon, Portugal.
- **Want the easiest transition?** Lake Chapala, Mexico. Drive-to distance, huge expat community, familiar culture.
- **Want tropical nature?** Costa Rica. Rainforests, volcanoes, beaches, all within a few hours.
- **Want European culture?** Lisbon, Portugal. EU access, history, and the best pastries on earth.

The Retirement Abroad Checklist



1. Research your top 2-3 destinations

Read real stories from people living there, not just travel blogs.

2. Run the numbers

Compare your current monthly expenses to estimated costs abroad. Include healthcare, housing, food, and travel home.

3. Understand your income sources

Social Security, pensions, and investment income all transfer overseas. Know what you will receive and in what currency.

4. Check visa requirements

Most countries offer retiree-specific visas. Requirements vary from proof of income to health insurance.

5. Take a scouting trip

Spend 2-4 weeks living like a local, not a tourist. Rent an apartment, shop at local markets, visit a doctor.

6. Talk to expats already there

Facebook groups, forums, and local meetups are the fastest way to get unfiltered information.

7. Consult a tax professional

US citizens are taxed on worldwide income. An expat-experienced CPA can help you plan efficiently.

8. Start small

You do not have to sell everything and move permanently. Many retirees start with a 3-6 month trial.

WHAT COMES NEXT

Your Morning Brief Starts Tomorrow

Every morning, Golden Horizons delivers fresh stories about retiring abroad, straight to your inbox. Real costs, real places, real people making it work.

Here is what to expect:

- A new destination to explore, with real cost breakdowns
- Food, culture, and daily-life stories from around the world
- Practical tips on visas, healthcare, and making the move
- Hidden gems you have never heard of

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